SOSC 13300:
Social Science Inquiry III

University of Chicago, Spring Quarter 2026.

Location: Pick Hall 222
Course time: Mon/Wed 3:00–4:20pm
Course dates: March 23–June 6, 2026
Course GitHub: https://github.com/UChicago-pol-methods/SOSC13300-S26

Instructor: Molly Offer-Westort; mollyow@uchicago.edu
Office hours: Book at https://calendar.app.google/DZYbbZHQqCSYAuUr5
Office: Pick Hall 328

Overview. This course is modified from a syllabus developed by Andy Eggers, which in turn built on a course created by Brendan Nyhan at Dartmouth College. In the final quarter of the Social Science Inquiry sequence, you will apply the research skills you developed in the first two quarters by contributing to a collaborative research project. The primary objective is to help you learn how to do research and how to critique research more effectively. A possible additional benefit is that our results may be strong enough to develop into a paper for submission, with students listed as coauthor—unless you decline that opportunity.

Course description. Our substantive focus is on climate change policy and politics, with special attention to how policy arguments are framed. Some arguments emphasize scientific information, some moral reasoning, and some economic consequences. Existing studies make different claims about which frames are effective, for whom they are effective, and whether some messages can even backfire. Early in the quarter, we will build enough substantive background to evaluate recent survey-based papers that we might replicate and extend. We will then choose a target paper, develop a research plan, pilot and refine our design, pre-register the study, field the survey, analyze the results, and write the paper together.

Each student will contribute to one part of the final study, and every student will write a version of the abstract, introduction, and discussion. At the end of the quarter, each student will also write a short reflection and critique of the combined draft. The course is designed to give you direct experience with the pleasures and frustrations of the research process while sharpening your ability to evaluate social science evidence.

Course objectives. This course should help you develop the ability to

- apply the tools you have learned so far in the sequence, including data analysis, programming, research design, and hypothesis testing;
- use those tools and additional writing skills to produce a polished piece of research;
- design and conduct an original experiment and analyze the results;
- understand the differences between observational and experimental research; and
- discuss important issues in climate change policy and politics.

Statistical software and computing. This version of the course repository is built around `R`, and you should expect to use `R` and RStudio throughout the quarter. You will need regular access to a computer with both installed. Some class meetings will include in-class computing work, so you should bring a laptop when possible. If access to a computer is a concern, please contact me and we will find a solution.

Assignments and grading. We will have a range of assignments in this course. Late work will not be accepted without prior permission.

Component	**Weight**
Class participation	14%
Research proposal	15%
Section write-up (theory, methods, or results)	15%
Other assignments	8% each, 56% total

Assignment files. Full assignment prompts live in the course repository's assignments folder.

Accommodations. Please reach out if you would like to request accommodations that would better facilitate your learning in this course. Student Disability Services is also available to provide resources and support and may approve specific academic accommodations: https://disabilities.uchicago.edu/.

Academic honesty and AI use. All students are expected to be familiar with and follow the University's academic honesty policies: https://studentmanual.uchicago.edu/academic-policies/academic-honesty-plagiarism/. For this course, you may use generative artificial intelligence tools such as Claude or Codex for generating code. No citation is required for code generated by AI, but you are responsible for understanding the code and verifying that it works correctly. You may also use AI tools for brainstorming, but you may not directly use AI-generated prose in course assignments. Because AI systems can hallucinate information, you should verify any factual claims they provide against reliable sources.

Course outline

Monday class	Wednesday class	Assignment
(3/23) Introduction; science and social science of climate change	(3/25) Science and social science of climate policy	(3/27) Problem set 1: data analysis refresher
(3/30) Discussion of replication/extension candidates, part 1	(4/1) Qualtrics for survey development	(4/3) Problem set 2: Qualtrics exercise
(4/6) Discussion of replication/extension candidates, part 2	(4/8) Project scoping and proposal workshop	Due Fri 4/10 at 3pm: proposal for our class research project (worth 15%)
(4/13) Research design and adaptive experimentation	(4/15) Discuss research plan; allocation of responsibilities	Due Tue 4/14 at 11:59pm: Problem set 3: data analysis from Qualtrics output

Monday class	Wednesday class	Assignment
(4/20) Group work for pilot	(4/22) Group work for pilot; data visualization	(4/24) Draft of group output (survey, literature spreadsheet, or PAP components). Pilot fielded over the weekend.
(4/27) Group work for PAP	(4/29) Group work for PAP	(5/1) Final version of group output using pilot results. PAP submitted and survey fielded over the weekend.
(5/4) Academic writing: theory, methods, and results	(5/6) Optional meeting for writing consult	(5/8) Section draft (theory, methods, or results), worth 15%. Partial combined draft distributed by Mon 5/11 at 5pm.
(5/11) Academic writing: introduction, abstract, and discussion	(5/13) Optional meeting for writing consult	(5/15) Remainder draft (abstract, introduction, and discussion). Full combined draft distributed by Wed 5/20 at 5pm.
(5/18) Presenting academic research	(5/20) Presentation of results	(5/29) Reflection and critique due

Detailed schedule

Class 1.1 Monday, March 23: Course orientation; the science and social science of climate change

- Overview of course objectives and structure: producing a publishable research paper on the politics of climate change.

Readings.

- None.

Class 1.2 Wednesday, March 25: The science and social science of climate policy

- An introduction to social framing and its possible role in advancing climate change policy.

Readings.

- Sparkman, G., N. Geiger, and E. U. Weber (2022). Americans experience a false social reality by underestimating popular climate policy support by nearly half. *Nature Communications 13*(1), 4779
- Chiancone, O., T. Chugh, B. De Leon-Duarte, A. C. Eggers, B. Fica, I. Goel, S. Konow, A. Lundsgaard, J. Margie, Z. Miller, et al. (2024). Good news about good news? the limited impacts of informing americans about recent success in climate change mitigation. *Research & Politics 11*(2), 20531680241256722
- The Climate Reality Project (2024). Why people ignore the science behind the climate crisis (and what you can do). Climate Reality Project blog `https://www.climaterealityproject.org/blog/why-people-ignore-science-behind-climate-crisis-and-what-you-can-do`

Assignment due Friday, March 27 at 3pm on Canvas. See `assignment01-data-analysis-refresher.R` for the full prompt.

Class 2.1 Monday, March 30: Discussion of replication/extension candidates, part 1

- Closely examine papers that we could replicate and extend in our own research. Part I focuses on background and framing the problem.

Readings.

- Swire-Thompson, B., J. DeGutis, and D. Lazer (2020). Searching for the backfire effect: Measurement and design considerations. *Journal of Applied Research in Memory and Cognition 9*(3), 286–299
- Druckman, J. N. and M. C. McGrath (2019). The evidence for motivated reasoning in climate change preference formation. *Nature Climate Change 9*(2), 111–119

- Nyhan, B. (2021). Why the backfire effect does not explain the durability of political misperceptions. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences 118*(15), e1912440117

Class 2.2 Wednesday, April 1: Qualtrics for survey development

- Develop facility with Qualtrics as a tool for collecting data for a survey experiment.

Readings.

- Diaz, G., C. Grady, and J. H. Kuklinski (2020). Survey experiments and the quest for valid interpretation. In L. Curini and R. Franzese (Eds.), *The SAGE Handbook of Research Methods in Political Science and International Relations*, Chapter 54, pp. 1036–1052. SAGE Publishing
- Leeper, T. J. (2018). The first mistake in crafting survey experiments. Blog post https://thomasleeper.com/2018/03/survey-experiment-first-mistake/

Assignment due Friday, April 3 at 3pm via Canvas. See `assignment02-qualtrics-exercise.md` for the full prompt.

Class 3.1 Monday, April 6: Discussion of replication/extension candidates, part 2

Before class, be ready to

- explain in simple terms what each study did and found;
- highlight something confusing, unclear, or unsatisfying about one of the papers; and
- assess whether it would be useful to replicate or extend these papers.

Readings.

- Goldwert, D. et al. (2026). A megastudy of behavioral interventions to catalyze public, political, and financial climate advocacy. *PNAS Nexus 5*(1), pgaf400
- Vlasceanu, M. et al. (2024). Addressing climate change with behavioral science: A global intervention tournament in 63 countries. *Science Advances 10*(6), eadj5778

- Voelkel, J. G. et al. (2026). A registered report megastudy on the persuasiveness of the most-cited climate messages. *Nature Climate Change 16*, 214–225

Class 3.2 Wednesday, April 8: Project scoping and proposal workshop

Readings.

- None.

Assignment due Friday, April 10 at 3pm via Canvas. See `assignment03-research-proposal.md` for the full prompt and team descriptions.

Class 4.1 Monday, April 13: Research design and adaptive experimentation

Readings.

- Gerber, A. S. and D. P. Green (2012). *Field experiments: Design, analysis, and interpretation*. W. W. Norton Chapter 13: "Writing an Experimental Proposal, Research Report, and Journal Article."

Assignment due Tuesday, April 14 at 11:59pm via Canvas. See `assignment04-qualtrics-output-analysis.ipynb` for the full prompt.

Class 4.2 Wednesday, April 15: Starting work on our research

- Discuss the decision about research focus and our overall plan.
- Begin work in groups, with short group reports at the end of class.
- Review group assignments, deliverables, and the research design.

Readings.

- Monogan, J. (2015). Research preregistration in political science: The case, counterarguments, and a response to critiques. *PS: Political Science & Politics 48*(2), 425–429
- Chen, L. and C. Grady (2021). 10 things to know about pre-analysis plans. EGAP `https://egap.org/resource/10-things-to-know-about-pre-analysis-plans/`

Additional reading.

- Banerjee, A., E. Duflo, A. Finkelstein, L. F. Katz, B. A. Olken, and A. Sautmann (2020). In praise of moderation: Suggestions for the scope and use of pre-analysis plans for RCTs in economics. NBER Working Paper 26993

Class 5.1 Monday, April 20: Group work on draft PAP components

- Continue group work, with short group reports at the end of class.

Class 5.2 Wednesday, April 22: Group work on draft PAP components

- Continue group work, with short group reports at the end of class.
- Discuss data visualization choices for presenting pilot and final results.

Assignment due Friday, April 24 at 3pm via Google Docs. See `assignment05-group-draft-pap-components.md` for the full prompt.

Class 6.1 Monday, April 27: Group work on PAP components

- Work with pilot data, with short group reports at the end of class.

Class 6.2 Wednesday, April 29: Group work on PAP components

- Continue group work, with short group reports at the end of class.

Assignment due Friday, May 1 at 3pm via Google Docs. See `assignment06-group-final-pap-components.md` for the full prompt.

Class 7.1 Monday, May 4: Academic writing: theory, methods, and results

Readings for reference.

- Mensh, B. and K. Kording (2017). Ten simple rules for structuring papers. *PLoS Computational Biology 13*(9), e1005619
- Coppock, A., D. P. Green, and E. Porter (2022). Does digital advertising affect vote choice? evidence from a randomized field experiment. *Research & Politics 9*(1), 1–7

Assignment due Friday, May 8 at 3pm via Canvas. See `assignment07-section-draft.md` for the full prompt.

Class 7.2 Wednesday, May 6: Optional meeting for writing consult

Attendance is not required, with the expectation that your group will meet outside of class time. Your group can also use class as a working session.

Class 8.1 Monday, May 11: Academic writing: abstract, introduction, and discussion

The partial combined draft will be distributed by Monday, May 11 at 5pm.

Class 8.2 Wednesday, May 13: Optional meeting for writing consult

Attendance is not required, with the expectation that your group will meet outside of class time. Your group can also use class as a working session.

Assignment due Friday, May 15 at 3pm via Canvas. See `assignment08-abstract-introduction-discussion.md` for the full prompt.

Class 9.1 Monday, May 18: Presenting research

- Data visualization and presentation of research findings.

Class 9.2 Wednesday, May 20: Presentation of results

The full combined draft will be distributed by Wednesday, May 20 at 5pm.

Assignment due Friday, May 29 at 3pm via Canvas. See `assignment09-reflection-and-critique.md` for the full prompt.